Case Study: Comparing a Hotel's In-House AV Quote Against an Independent Quote

For a one-day corporate event in a downtown Toronto luxury hotel, an independent AV quote came in about 48% below the venue's in-house quote before tax, for comparable core equipment.

Project profile

Item	Detail
Event	One-day corporate mastermind
Venue	Luxury hotel ballroom, downtown Toronto
Attendance	About 60 guests
Quotes compared	The venue's in-house AV provider and one independent AV company
Result	About $18.3K in-house against about $9.5K independent, before tax (roughly 48% lower)
Services provided	AVL, side-by-side comparison, plain-English client email, vendor coordination
Basis of figures	Vendor quotes before tax; EventStudio's own fee is not included

Background

The organizer was planning a single-day event built around talks and group discussion. The room did not need a production in the theatrical sense. It needed reliable presentation technology that every attendee could see and hear.

The venue's in-house AV provider issued a quote for the full setup. The organizer had no written specification to test it against, so there was no practical way to tell which lines were required and which were habit or default.

Technical requirements

Area	Requirement
Display	Four large TVs, all fed from a single laptop at the podium
Presenting	Podium and slide clicker
Audio	Three wireless microphones; four speakers with a small mixer

Area	Requirement
Lighting	Uplighting
Crew	Technician coverage for the event, plus load-in and load-out labour

Approach

1. **Specification.** We wrote one AVL (audio-video-lighting list) from the event's requirements. The same list was used to price both options, so the quotes described identical scope.
2. **Line-by-line review.** Each quote was re-added and checked against its printed total, then sorted into common categories: video and signal, rigging, audio, lighting, podium, labour, freight and service charges.
3. **Side-by-side comparison.** The categories were set next to each other so that differences in scope, crew and fees could be traced to specific lines.
4. **Client communication.** We wrote a plain-English email covering what matched, what differed, what remained open and which dates mattered.
5. **Coordination.** We put follow-up questions to both providers and tracked the answers, so that neither quote was left with unstated assumptions.

Findings

The in-house quote totalled about $18.3K before tax. The independent quote came in at about $9.5K before tax. Core equipment was comparable: four large TVs fed from one laptop, wireless microphones, four speakers with a mixer, uplighting and a podium.

The in-house quote broke down as follows (rounded):

Category	Approx. amount	Share of quote
Video (TVs and signal)	$6.0K	33%
Labour	$4.6K	25%
Service charge (22%)	$3.3K	18%
Audio, lighting and podium	$2.9K	16%
Rigging and freight	$1.4K	8%
Total	$18.3K	100%

Three factors accounted for most of the difference between the two quotes:

- **Service charge.** The in-house quote added a 22% service charge on top of equipment, labour and freight. At roughly $3.3K it was nearly a fifth of the total. The independent quote carried no equivalent line.

- **Labour.** The in-house quote scheduled a larger crew for load-in and load-out. Labour was the second-largest category.
- **Rigging.** The in-house quote included rigging line items, about $0.8K in total, that a TV-based setup does not require.

Items left open

Neither quote was treated as final until four scope items were confirmed in writing. They could move either number, so they were listed for the client rather than assumed.

Open item	Why it matters
Stands and mounts	Determines what hardware each TV needs and who supplies it
Truss	Determines whether any overhead support is needed, and drives rigging charges
Signal path	Confirms how one podium laptop reaches all four displays: cabling, converters, switching
Speaker stands	Confirms whether they are included or supplied separately

Two further points applied to both prices. A dedicated operator to advance slides and run music was not included in either, at roughly $750 extra. The venue's load-in and load-out windows and its rules for outside vendors also needed confirming.

Commercial terms to review

The in-house quote carried terms that affect the real cost of the decision:

- The quote was valid for 30 days from issue.
- Cancellation was free until about 30 days before the event, then 50% from 30 to 15 days out, 75% from 14 to 3 days out, and 100% inside 72 hours.
- A credit application was due at least 30 days before the event. Without one, the provider could require a deposit of up to the full amount.

These dates were set out for the client so the decision could be made inside the free-cancellation window.

Outcome

The client received a written specification, a line-by-line comparison, a plain-English summary and a dated list of decisions. The choice of provider, and the contract with that provider, remain the client's. EventStudio's fee was waived on this job.

Takeaways for planners

1. A venue quote prices whatever scope the venue assumed. Until the scope is written down, it cannot be compared with anything.
2. Comparisons are only valid on identical scope. Quote the same list to every provider.
3. Review labour and service-charge lines first. They are where the largest differences appeared.
4. Record open items in writing before either quote is called final.
5. Confirm the venue's outside-vendor policy and cancellation terms before collecting quotes.

About AV Compare

AV Compare is EventStudio's service for meetings of 50 to 500 people. The process has four steps:

1. The client provides the date, venue, room and a short agenda.
2. EventStudio delivers a written AV specification and three quotes against it, in about a week.
3. Required and optional items are marked, so that nothing the agenda does not need is carried into the price.
4. The client selects the supplier and contracts with it directly.

The client pays EventStudio a flat fee. EventStudio receives nothing from the AV companies and adds no markup on equipment, so the price difference stays with the client.

Notes on the figures

All figures are approximate, taken from vendor quotes and stated before HST. The client, venue and vendors are not named.